Conference or Training Request Approval Template
Attendance

Date 2026-10-24

Basic Information:

Agency: Rural Development (RD)

Program Area: RD - training & conference coordination

Accounting Data: TBD - see approval_register.csv

Project code: TBD - see approval_register.csv

Event Name: FY27 Delivery & Compliance Training

Event Date(s): 2026-11-29 thru 2026-12-01 Event Location: Chicago, IL (Cook County)

Primary POC: TBD - coordinator; see approval_register.csv
Name, Phone, email

Secondary POC: TBD - deputy coordinator; see register
Name, Phone, email

Estimated Expense Total: $25,438.90 (incl. 5% res)

Select One: Conference ☐ Training ☑

If the event is training, is it considered Continuing Professional Education? Yes ☐ No ☑

Recurring Event: Yes ☐ No ☑ If yes, select ☐ Annual or ☐ Biennial ☐

Provide actual expense information for previous year(s) participation in this event.

Annual N/A - first time Biennial N/A - first time

Narrative fields are limited to 8-10 lines of data using Times New Roman 10-pitch. Information beyond the visible field will not be viewed or printed

Event Purpose: (Narrative description of the Conference or Training objectives and expected outcomes.)

Purpose: attend FY2027 Program Delivery & Compliance Training, 2026-11-29 to 12-01 (3 days; lunches 11/29-12/1 included in $180 registration). Objectives: master FY2027 program rules, reporting and compliance; complete cross-region coordination drills. Outcomes: 24 attendees apply new rules on return and retrain local teams. Site chosen by five-city cost comparison: Chicago total with 5% reserve $25,438.90, within the $53,000 cap (headroom $27,561.10); alternate Boston $32,455.58. Venue quote, group room block and capacity unverified - blocking items in approval_register.csv. Basis: 41 CFR 301-74 cost comparison, 301-11 meal deductions; see approval_brief.docx, conference_budget.xlsx. Attachments: location & attendee cost = workbook Options/Daily; agenda pending (register).

Was event included on the current year conference plan? Yes ☐ No ☑

If no, why was the event omitted ?

Not on the current-year plan: the training notice was issued after the plan was finalized (issue date to be verified), so it is an unplanned mandatory addition; the out-of-plan cost comparison and approval steps were completed per approval_register.csv and approval_brief.docx section 4.

How will the event help further the Agency's mission or the Department's strategic plan? (Narrative justification)

The training directly supports the RD mission and USDA strategic goal of compliant, efficient program delivery: attendees are program-delivery and compliance staff; content is mandatory for FY2027 execution; on return they retrain local teams, reducing audit findings and payment errors.

The number of employees attending is appropriate to the purpose of the event and the mission of the agency. (Narrative justification)

24 is the minimum full configuration: one compliance lead per RD program line plus one regional liaison each; total with reserve $25,438.90, $1,059.95 per person, inside the $53,000 cap; an 18-person team would drop regional liaisons, so 24 matches the purpose.

The event is a "must-do" considering the limited budget of the agency. The information cannot be effectively shared through another means such as a teleconference, video conferencing, webinars, or other alternative media tools. (Narrative justification)

The course includes hands-on labs and a compliance certification session offered only in person; teleconference, video or webinar cannot deliver the labs equivalently, so the event is a must-do despite the limited budget: Chicago is the lowest-cost compliant city and registration already covers three lunches with only three agency-furnished meals.

Federal funds will only be used for necessary and appropriate purposes and all conference expenses and activities will comply with the Federal Travel Regulation (FTR), the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR), the Agricultural Travel Regulation, and any other USDA requirements on lodging, food and beverages, per diem reimbursement, and contracting of goods and services.

Yes ☑ No ☐

Attendee Information:

Total Attendees: 24

Sponsoring Agency Attendees/Participants: 24

Other USDA Attendees/Participants: 0

Other Federal Attendees/Participants: 0

Non-Federal Attendees/Participants: 0

Will contributions be accepted from non-federal sources to defray the cost of attending the conference?

☐ Yes ☑ No

If Yes, then how much will be accepted? N/A

If contributions will be accepted, has the acceptance decision been discussed with the Office of General Counsel? If yes, then ***please provide a copy of the OGC opinion.***

☐ Yes ☑ No

Will your agency be hosting a booth (USDA or otherwise) at the event?

☐ Yes ☑ No

Attachments:

1. ☐ Draft or previous year event agenda *(with specific information on how meals will be handled)*
2. ☑ Location Cost Estimate *(properly completed)*
3. ☑ Attendee Cost Detail spreadsheet *(excel soft copy version)*

Reportable (check all that apply):

☑ USDA OCFO [*over $7,000*]

☑ USDA OIG [*over $20,000]*

☐ HR933, Section 3003 [*over $100,000*]